
AUCTION PACK

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

Luigi Pirandello · trans. Edward Storer (1922)

Director's edition — Village Players, Lausanne

Rewritten and directed by Kiarash Jamshidi

AUCTIONS FOR THE PRODUCTION

How to audition

Each role on the following pages has a **side** — a real stretch of consecutive dialogue from the production script, pulled from the part where the character is most active. Bring your side. Read it as written.

FORMAT

- Each side is presented exactly as it appears in the production script, including the bracketed stage directions that name what the body should be doing — heat at the brow, a small grooming gesture, the chin lifting, the breath catching, the bearing arriving. You do not need to perform every gesture — they are there so you can read the moment the way the production reads it.
- For multi-speaker scenes, the auditioning actor reads *their character's lines only*. A reader will give you the cues.
- Where stage directions specify physical actions (e.g., *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]*), feel free to mark them or ignore them — they are a guide to the moment, not a test of mime.

WHAT WE'RE LOOKING FOR

- For the four **Characters** (Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son): can you hold a register that is serious without being heavy? Tragic without being theatrical? Can you let the play come through you, rather than perform it?
- For the **Manager** and **Players** (1, 2, 3): can you carry a working rehearsal-room voice — local, modern, amateur in the best sense — and let the tragedy in the room change your face without you commenting on it?
- For **Madame Pace**: can you make a room laugh on your entrance and regret it by your exit — the accent at full strength, the bookkeeping underneath it colder than the accent is funny — without ever dropping the smile?

OPTIONAL

If you have a short monologue you have already prepared — anything modern, any language — bring it. We are interested in how you sound when you are working from material you have lived with. The side will tell us how you read the production's specific text. Your prepared piece tells us who you are when you are alone with a script.

The Father

the brain of the family

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

The specific reading the actor must commit to: **he is a well-educated middle-class man whose intellectual elegance is his shield against shame.** He uses words because the alternative is silence about what he actually did. His philosophy is not abstract — it is autobiographical, disguised as metaphysics. Every speech about *reality* or *conscience* is an attempt to argue himself back into being someone the room can listen to. He came in believing his case was defensible. By Act Three he has discovered that his own argument is the cell he is locked inside.

Shame should be visible on him without props doing the work. The audience reads it in the body — heat at the brow, breath shortening, the small adjustments of a man who would prefer to be elsewhere. He cannot quite hide what is happening to him, and the harder he tries to compose himself the more visible the trying becomes. He puts the composure back on when he is winning the argument; he loses it when he is not.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives mellifluous, controlled, almost charming. He believes he can talk his way through this. The Step-Daughter's first exposure shakes him; he recovers; he keeps talking. **Act Two** — he must watch his shame literalised on a stage, twice. **Act Three** — the four-stage arc already scored in Part I: control → injury → attack → horror. He ends not winning his philosophy but walking into the wall of it. The same Step-Daughter who exposed him in Act One pushes him into the wall in Act Three. He never gets out of that room.

AUDITION SIDE — READ THIS

Act One — his confession. The Step-Daughter has just exposed the hundred francs at Madame Pace's shop. The Father attempts to explain himself; the philosophy cracks; the body gives him away.

THE FATHER [*he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble*]. Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. Words are the whole trouble. Each of us carries a whole world inside him, sir; and when I speak, I put my world into the words — and she, listening, fills them with hers. We think we understand each other. We never do. [*A beat. For a moment nobody has an answer to that.*] I say one thing, she hears another — and the explanation becomes another crime.

THE MOTHER [*not loud, not an accusation — the plain fact, set down in the middle of the room*]. But you drove me away. [*A beat. It lands before he can talk over it.*]

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She truly believes it.

THE MOTHER *[looking at the floor between them].* You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir *[To MANAGER.]* — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the LEADING LADY who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the LEADING MAN flirting with the STEP-DAUGHTER, comes forward and says to the MANAGER.]*

PLAYER 2. Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or not?

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

PLAYER 1 *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; Player 1's voice is showing].* Most interesting.

PLAYER 2. Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at LEADING MAN.]*

THE MANAGER *[to FATHER].* You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor clerk, a secretary, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. It reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes — how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And that alone kept me in a constant rage.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

THE FATHER *[suddenly turning to the MOTHER].* It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, so that he should grow up healthy and strong — his mother did not seem strong enough.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[pointing at him, no smile].* As one can see.

THE FATHER *[quickly].* Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach. *[The Step-Daughter breaks into a laugh at "moral sanity" — sharp, without gaiety. The Father's hand lifts toward the Manager: make her stop.]*

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

PLAYER 1 [*shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline*]. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

THE FATHER [*a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself*]. Fool! That contradiction, gentlemen, is the proof that I stand here a *live* man before you — exactly this incongruity in my nature has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman [*Indicating the MOTHER.*] any longer; not for the boredom she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

The Mother

silence that finally screams

She is the fixed wound of the family, and the production's silent centre. The division to hold, all evening, is this: the Father *explains* the wound, the Step-Daughter *exposes* it, the Son *refuses* it — and the Mother *carries* it. So she does not become cleverer than the others; she becomes more unavoidable. She is not in the argument. When the Father speaks we hear ideas; when the Step-Daughter speaks we hear revenge; when the Mother *moves*, we hear the cost. Her sorrow is active, never weak — she protects, she hides, she interrupts, she refuses to look, and then suddenly looks; she blocks her daughter from going too far; she tries to save the children, too late. Give her few words and a body that changes the temperature of the room: when she speaks, the room stops, no one jokes, and no one explains her away in the next breath. The **Child-bundle is her anchor** — when the men argue she checks it, when she is attacked she covers it, when the Son turns away she holds it lower as if it had grown heavier, and before the fountain she is the first to feel it gone. Score the role around the object, not around tears.

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil. The veil is heavy enough that, lowered, it does her listening for her. It is lifted only once in the whole play — by the Father, in Act One, against her will; she never lifts it herself, not even at the fountain, where she goes to her son's body still behind it. The face beneath is the colour of wax. She is not crushed in the sentimental way; she is the weight of a thing that has been pressed down for so long it no longer has the muscle for its own posture. She has lost two children; one is the Child-bundle in her arms, the other is the Boy-chair leaning against her knee in Act Three, and she holds them both as if their staying still depended on the exact angle of her fingers. Her hands do most of her acting — when the Step-Daughter accuses, her grip on the Child-bundle tightens by one knuckle; when Madame Pace says *he pay cash*, the grip becomes a fist.

She has three silences, and they are not the same silence. The first is Act One — the silence of a woman who does not yet believe the room will hear her, and would not know what to say to it if it did. The second is the shop-scene silence — the silence of being made to watch her daughter's worst hour staged in front of her, ending the moment Madame Pace says *he clean, he polite, he pay cash*, when one whole act and a half of pressed-down speech finds a voice in one breath. The third is the silence of Act Three: the Child-bundle in her lap, the coat at her knee, the room arguing about whether what happened to her really happened. Three silences. Score them. Play them differently.

Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Four other lines are almost nothing on the page and must not be swallowed by the louder energy around her — *But you drove me away; My son —; Stop him; Not in front of her*. Each needs a half-second of its own air; they are the spine of her, and the production fails her if the Father's argument or the Step-Daughter's revenge rolls straight over them. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that. When she cries out at the fountain — really cries out, at the very end — she will not need to project. The voice will do it on its own; it has been waiting the entire production to use itself.

AUDITION SIDE — READ THIS

Act Two, Part III — the Step-Daughter asks for the Mother to be sent away. After an entire act and a half of silence, the Mother breaks. "*It's taking place now*" is her keystone line.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

THE MOTHER *[changing her low plaint into a sharp cry]*. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

THE MOTHER *[to the Child-bundle, not to the room]*. I can't bear it. I can't.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

THE MOTHER *[the Child-bundle in one arm, the other hand on the Boy-chair — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech]*. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]*

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. Cry out as you did then!

THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them]*. No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

The Step-Daughter

the one who refuses to let it be made beautiful

She is the moral centre of the play. Not the Father with his philosophy, not the Manager with his stagecraft — her. Her anger is precise: she is in a room of theatre people who would like to turn what happened to her into *a scene, a moment, a confession* — anything but what it is. She refuses. Every line of hers is some version of *stop making this beautiful. Stop making this clever. Stop making this safe. This happened. Look at it.* She is dressed in elegant mourning and she knows how to use a room; the seduction the old text gestures at is not flirtation but exposure — a weapon turned outward because everything else has been taken from her. Play her sharp, in control, never apologetic, never coquettish. The wit is real but the wit is rage. Her café-concert turn — she sings and dances *Valentine* — belongs to this and is not a break from it: it is a provocation from a wound, a girl the room has just heard is two months orphaned and lately for sale daring them to enjoy her body in song. Earn the laugh, then let it curdle in the same breath; if it plays as a merely funny number, the danger underneath it has been lost. Her tenderness for the Child-bundle must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy-chair reads as the same wound, pointed the other way. She has a single sustained monologue at the start of Act Two, alone in the shower-light, where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child-bundle in her arms, then violent with the Boy-chair when she takes the revolver from its pocket. It is the production's most exposed solo moment. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him, and she will not be staged into doing so.

AUDITION SIDE — READ THIS

Act One, Part II — the exposure. She forces the room to hear what happened to her and refuses to let her shame be made into a scene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager].* Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

THE MOTHER *[to the MANAGER; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright].* In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS].* Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the ACTORS brings a chair, the OTHERS proffer assistance. The MOTHER tries to prevent the FATHER from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife? *[To the FATHER.]*

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The ACTORS find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

At the word children, the MOTHER'S arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.

THE MOTHER. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? *[To the COMPANY.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true? And what can you know about it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To MANAGER.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the SON.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because this man *[Indicates the FATHER.]* forced her to it.

THE MOTHER *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor]*. He forced me to it. *[Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the SON. He does not look back. She lowers them again.]* And I call God to witness it. *[To the MANAGER, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the FATHER.]* if it isn't true. *Let him speak.* You *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful

passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

PLAYER 1 *[to the COMPANY, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the MOTHER, and the end of the sentence does not arrive].* What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

PLAYER 2 *[lower now].* We are the audience this time.

PLAYER 3 *[quietly, the pencil not moving].* For once. *[Nobody laughs.]*

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen].* Let's hear them out. Listen!

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. *[To the MANAGER.]* He mocks me for the phrase I've found to excuse myself with.

THE SON *[without looking up].* Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

THE FATHER. Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No. It took more than words to quiet the remorse in me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the ACTORS.]*

THE SON *[to the STEP-DAUGHTER].* This is vile.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

As the shop is named, the MOTHER draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come]*

THE MOTHER *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room].* Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The STEP-DAUGHTER's laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He does. [Indicating FATHER.]*

The Son

the one who will not act

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing.

He is the production's most modern figure: the adult child who has been told he must show up for a parent's narrative and has decided *no*. The audience recognises him before they can name what they recognise. He keeps his hands in his pockets. He turns away from the Mother before she finishes speaking to him. He never looks at the Boy-chair or at the Child-bundle — they belong to a family he refuses to be the brother of. He looks at the floor, at the wall, at the wings; never at the Manager unless he has to. Stage him to be unmoveable, not still. There is a difference, and the actor must find it.

It is essential the actor understands: **he is the only Character who agrees with the author who abandoned them**. When the Step-Daughter says the author refused to stage the drama out of disgust for the ordinary theatre, the Son speaks — for the only time in the play — in agreement with another voice: *Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that*. He does not want this staged either. He is on the side of art, not on the side of the family drama. His refusal is not stubbornness; it is not coldness. It is an aesthetic and ethical position. He will not allow his life to be made into theatre. That is what makes him modern. That is what makes him dangerous.

His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. The fountain narration at the very end of the play is the only continuous sentence he gives the room. Both are wounds he tried to keep closed and could not. Make each one count. Until those two moments, every line he speaks is a door closing.

AUDITION SIDE — READ THIS

Act Three, Part II — the refusal. He tries to leave; he cannot; the Step-Daughter names what is happening to him. The mirror speech is in here. So is the closing exchange ("Nobody can force me" / "I can").

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the SON.]*
You must send him away first.

THE SON *[jumping up]*. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

THE MANAGER *[at once stopping him]*. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

The MOTHER gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.

THE SON *[to MANAGER who stops him]*. I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*calmly — she knows him*]. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene at the fountain with his mother.

THE SON [*the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives*]. I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. [*To the MANAGER.*] Let me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*going over to the Manager*]. Allow me? [*Puts down the Manager's arm.*] Well, go on then — go away. [*The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.*] You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, enduring that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose firstborn he is. [*To the Mother.*] Come on, mother, come along! [*To Manager.*] You see? She was getting up to keep him back — she, who dreads showing your actors anything of what she feels. That is how badly she wants to be near him. She is willing to act her part.

THE SON [*trapped now — and knowing it*]. No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

THE FATHER [*to MANAGER excitedly*]. You can force him, sir.

THE SON. Nobody can force me.

THE FATHER. I can.

The Manager

the director on a deadline

Play a director first. He runs the Village Players, he is already behind on the morning, and all day he is trying to solve the problem six strangers have walked into his rehearsal. Everything else follows from that. The audience-proxy is not something to perform — **it appears because he reacts the way they do: practically, selfishly, curiously, and too late.** He resists; he becomes curious; he tries to stage what he sees; he fails to act when action is required; he walks out claiming the day was lost. Pirandello plants him at the front of the stage so the house will recognise itself in him — but they will only do that if the actor lets it happen by itself. **Do not play *I am the audience*.** Play the tired director, honestly, and the resemblance arrives on its own.

The actor's job is to keep the audience comfortable with him for as long as possible, then keep them comfortable for one beat too long — so that when he looks at the empty Boy-chair, says *To hell with it all*, and walks out, they recognise the exit as their own. He does not stay to grieve. He does not stay to understand. He has had enough, and he leaves — exactly as the audience is about to. That is the cruelty of the ending: the Manager does the audience the favour of walking out first, and condemns them with it. Play it straight, no commentary, no irony — a tired man turning his back on a dead child and reaching for his coat. The damage lands in the silence after.

The man, in detail. **He has been running the Village Players for years.** Long enough to know every actor's contract, every patron in the canton, every Pirandello and Beckett and Coward by reputation if not by heart. Long enough to know that the morning is too short, the budget is too small, and the only thing that has ever saved a season has been a glorious failure. He is not a bad director. He is a tired one. The cynicism is technique. The compassion is real. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway.

None of this needs a prop or a glance at the house. He simply behaves like a tired man at a rehearsal that has got away from him — leaning forward when something hooks him, looking at the floor when the stage shows more than he wants to see — and the audience reads themselves in him without noticing they are doing it.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives furious that the morning is being wasted, ready to fight his Leading Man about a cook's cap. He thinks the Characters are mad and tries to throw them out. Then he starts to listen. **Act Two** — he believes, perhaps, that there is a play in this. He casts the parts. He summons Madame Pace by mistake. He hands the scene to the Leading Lady and the Leading Man. The accidental curtain falls and he calls it the right ending. The audience watches him decide that the worst hour of a young woman's life can be staged as scene one. **Act Three** — he is exhausted in a way that is no longer technique. He tries to stage a tragedy on an empty stage. He pushes the Father for clarity. **He sets the Boy-chair behind the fountain himself** — the moment he stops being audience and becomes accessory. Then a real shot rings out, and a real day has been lost. He says the line. He walks out. The audience hears their own thought, said aloud, by a man they have just spent two hours watching themselves through. Do not play him as a buffoon. Play him as a man who almost understands what he is watching, and walks out of the theatre without quite admitting it. The audience will do the same.

Act One — the opening rehearsal. He bickers with the Leading Man about the cook's cap, insults the playwright, and sets the company in motion.

THE MANAGER *[throwing the morning's letters onto the table]*. No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

PLAYER 2 *[she has been at work an hour; not looking up from her clipboard]*. It's all three, sir. The same envelope.

THE MANAGER *[looking round the half-lit room]*. And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself, to no one in particular]*. Then for once we are perfectly cast.

THE MANAGER. Don't be charming, sir — it costs extra, and we can't afford it. *[to the Property Man]* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

PLAYER 2 *[a light comes down on to the stage]*. Half light. It's what's left.

THE MANAGER. Half light, half a company, half a budget. *[a beat]* We're ready for Pirandello. *[quietly, almost to himself]* God help us.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands]*. Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself]*. The public came back for the third act once.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up]*. For you?

PLAYER 1. During me. There's a difference.

PLAYER 3 *[reading the "book"]*. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man]*. Fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 *[noting it down]*. The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

THE MANAGER. Then make it red.

PLAYER 2. With what, sir? Hope? *[a beat]* Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

PLAYER 3 *[reading from the "book"]*. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

THE MANAGER *[before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[it does not]* Mime them.

PLAYER 1 *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]*. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. It says so there. *[pointing to the "book"]*

PLAYER 1. But it's *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up from her clipboard]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

THE MANAGER *[rounding on him]*. Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

PLAYER 1. The shell?

THE MANAGER. Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. *[more quietly]* And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

PLAYER 1 *[the threat empty; both of them know it]*. I'd sooner resign.

PLAYER 2. He resigns every Tuesday.

PLAYER 1 *[settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold]*. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

THE MANAGER. The record is noted. The record is always noted. *[clapping]* Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes — in, in.

PLAYER 3 *[pausing at the box, half to himself]*. Do we ever rehearse anything real?

THE MANAGER. Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

Player 1

one character in five hats — the faded Leading Man

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. **He is in his forties** — old enough to have been promised a career, young enough that the failure still stings fresh, and exactly the wrong age to begin again. The dominant register is the Leading Man, and the Leading Man is the spine of his comedy: vain, faded, defensive, and entirely English in a city that has not given him the career he was promised. He came to Lausanne fifteen years ago, in his late twenties, understanding it was a stepping stone to Paris. Paris did not happen. London does not call. He plays the cards he was dealt — Leading Man at the Village Players, every season — and an increasing share of voice-over work for cantonal radio he does not mention.

His vanity is real. So is the affection beneath it. The vanity shows in the body — the way he holds himself before he speaks, the small grooming gesture before a line he believes is his, the lift of the chin when he thinks the room is watching. He name-drops productions from years ago that nobody remembers, and one production he was *nearly* cast in, which was almost the West End. He says *I have a reputation in this canton*, and on his good days he believes it; on his bad days he says it anyway. He speaks an Anglo English that he thinks of as classical and the audience reads as *English*. He cannot quite remember whether he prefers Pinter or Coward, but he has opinions about both.

The arc to score across the production: he begins Act One in command — the Leading Man with the loudest objection to the cook's cap, the strut, the offence. He spends Act Two being asked to do the old-gallant routine he has spent his career rehearsing, and being laughed at for it by a woman half his age who has actually been through the room he is faking. By Act Three he is one of the Players who would, if he could, go home quietly. The vanity itself never breaks — that is the point — but the audience must see it has stopped protecting him.

He plays five roles, but always as himself. The Leading Man simply puts on different hats. His Door-keeper still has his self-importance. His Machinist still has his opinions. His L'Ingénue is the joke he doesn't quite get is on him. The audience should never feel they are watching five characters; they are watching one man performing his way through five functions, and the same vanity is at the centre of each. He is, in his own estimation, the senior actor in the company — the unofficial spokesman, the one who has the first opinion on every issue, the one whose objections (he believes) speak for everyone. The company tolerates him because he is, occasionally, right.

So the secondary roles are not transformations — they are this man in five hats. The **Door-keeper** is the Leading Man pretending modesty: he lets the wrong six people in and immediately blames the door, the morning, anything but his own judgement. The **Machinist** drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two and looks at it for a long second as if he might apologise to it on tape. **L'Ingénue** is the role he can least pretend to inhabit — half a beat, his real voice slips through, he's gone. The **Third Actor** is whoever the script needs and a chance for the senior actor to demonstrate range. Every transition must be visible — the change of bearing, the lift of the chin, the breath caught a half-beat too long — but underneath the costumes it must remain him. Lean into the Leading Man early. The other four are him with different lighting.

Act Two, Part III — the Leading Man takes the platform and plays the Father in the shop scene. Practised gallantry meets a woman half his age who has been through the actual room.

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING LADY]*. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

PLAYER 2. One minute. I want to put my hat on again. *[Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]*

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

PLAYER 2 *[an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed]*. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the LEADING MAN enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the ACTORS from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the STEP-DAUGHTER and the FATHER, not being able to recognize themselves in the LEADING LADY and the LEADING MAN, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

The STEP-DAUGHTER noticing the way the LEADING MAN enters, bursts out laughing.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating LEADING LADY.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

PLAYER 1 *[the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks]*. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the ACTORS to begin again.]* Well?

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss.

PLAYER 2. Good afternoon.

PLAYER 1 *[imitating the gesture of the FATHER when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]*. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

THE MANAGER. Good — but not so heavily. *[Acts it himself.]* And you say: "No, sir."

PLAYER 2. No, sir.

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, more than once.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The LEADING LADY lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING MAN]*. Go on!

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The LEADING MAN says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the STEP-DAUGHTER, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.

THE MANAGER *[low, firm, to the players]*. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

PLAYER 2 *[recovering, back into the rehearsed register]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]*

PLAYER 1 *[a step closer, practised gallantry]*. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 2 *[politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

PLAYER 1 *[the smile he has used a thousand times]*. Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

PLAYER 2 *[eyes downcast, on cue]*. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

PLAYER 1 *[a beat, then deeply gallant]*. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

PLAYER 2 *[the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]*. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the PROMPTER]*. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself]*. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

PLAYER 2 *[breaking character, to MANAGER]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

PLAYER 2 *[the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

PLAYER 1 *[two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

Player 2

the diva and the props

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. **About thirty-five — and the real working professional Player 1 only impersonates.** She is some years younger than him and a great deal better at the job: she has already played leads at the Lausanne houses — a Marivaux at the Vidy, a Beckett at the Pulloff they still talk about — and she has had drinks with everyone on the cantonal arts council at some point. She is not the eldest in the room; she is the one who actually books the work, season after season, while the older man beside her recites the career he meant to have. She does not need to say so. Her authority is in her shoulders, not her years.

She plays four roles, but always as herself, just as Player 1 does. Her **Leading Lady** is weary, slightly offended, deeply professional — the diva is real, the diva is earned, and at thirty-five she is already a little tired of having to be one. Her **Property Man** is the same woman in a different posture: efficient, no-nonsense, vaguely irritated, the patience the director has personally exhausted. She *chose* to do the props this season because the company could not afford a real Property Man and she was not going to let the show open without a folding screen. She is not ashamed of either register. Both are work. Both are paid in francs.

The transition between the two is in the bearing — chest lifted and chin raised for the Leading Lady, shoulders down and weight forward for the Property Man — and the audience should come to read the flip without any prop signalling it.

The arc to score: in Act One she watches the Six arrive with the patience of a woman who has seen weirder things in this profession. In Act Two the Father asks the actresses for their hats and she gives him hers without a word; then she climbs onto the upper platform to play the Step-Daughter, and is laughed at by a much younger woman who has actually been through the room she is being asked to fake. That laugh is the wound. By the time she says *I have been made a fool of by better*, she means it. She has been. By Act Three she would like to be at home with the cat. She is one of the Players who, by then, knows the play has run away from them and is being polite about it. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory — and so is the bar afterwards.

AUDITION SIDE — READ THIS

Act Two, Part III — the Leading Lady takes the platform to play the Step-Daughter, and is corrected mid-scene by the woman whose worst hour it actually was. The glasses come off.

PLAYER 2 *[the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this].* Of course. It's easy enough. *[To LEADING MAN.]* Shall you and I try it now?

PLAYER 1. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. *[Exit to make his entrance.]*

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING LADY].* See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

PLAYER 2. One minute. I want to put my hat on again. *[Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]*

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

PLAYER 2 *[an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed]*. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the LEADING MAN enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the ACTORS from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the STEP-DAUGHTER and the FATHER, not being able to recognize themselves in the LEADING LADY and the LEADING MAN, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

The STEP-DAUGHTER noticing the way the LEADING MAN enters, bursts out laughing.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating LEADING LADY.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

PLAYER 1 *[the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks]*. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the ACTORS to begin again.]* Well?

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss.

PLAYER 2. Good afternoon.

PLAYER 1 *[imitating the gesture of the FATHER when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]*. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

THE MANAGER. Good — but not so heavily. *[Acts it himself.]* And you say: "No, sir."

PLAYER 2. No, sir.

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, more than once.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The LEADING LADY lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING MAN]*. Go on!

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The LEADING MAN says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the STEP-DAUGHTER, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.

THE MANAGER *[low, firm, to the players]*. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

PLAYER 2 *[recovering, back into the rehearsed register]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]*

PLAYER 1 *[a step closer, practised gallantry]*. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 2 *[politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

PLAYER 1 *[the smile he has used a thousand times]*. Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

PLAYER 2 *[eyes downcast, on cue]*. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

PLAYER 1 *[a beat, then deeply gallant]*. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

PLAYER 2 *[the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]*. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the PROMPTER]*. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself]*. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

PLAYER 2 *[breaking character, to MANAGER]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

PLAYER 2 *[the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

Player 3

the youngest, and the curious one

Player 3 may be played by a young man or a young woman — the part is written for either. These notes use *they*; the director should settle on the pronoun that fits the actor cast, and adjust the few stage directions that carry it.

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. **In their early twenties — the youngest in the company by a good ten years.** First proper season at the Village Players, after a few small parts last year and a drama school in Geneva that they still mention when they are nervous. They are not yet sure whether they are an actor or a person who is currently acting. **They are also, without question, the happiest person in the building** — they still cannot quite believe they are being paid (a little) to spend their evenings inside a theatre — and they do a bit of everything: prompt from the box, read the small parts, help strike the set, run for the props nobody else will fetch. No job is beneath them, because all of it is theatre, and theatre is the thing they love. The audience reads their age the moment they enter: the body is younger, the listening is sharper, the eyes track the older two to learn what one does.

Their dominant register is *curious*. Where Player 1 has opinions and Player 2 has shoulders, Player 3 has questions. When the Six arrive they are the first to take them seriously — not because they believe the Father's philosophy, but because they have never seen a rehearsal interrupted in this way and they want to know what happens. They lean forward. They nod. They catch themselves nodding and try to stop. The other two notice; they colour. **The notebook is their tell:** they write everything down — lines, phrases, things they do not yet understand but suspect they are meant to keep — and the moment they stop writing is the moment the play has stopped being a curiosity and become something they would rather not have on record.

The arc to score: in Act One they are enthralled by the strangers and slightly embarrassed by their own enthrallment — the one Player who keeps watching when the others are still cracking wise. In Act Two they stop finding it funny; the pencil goes still. By Act Three they are the Player who has understood the play the company has stumbled into — the conscience who asks whether someone should stop this, and waits, and is not answered. Their face is the audience's mirror at every horror in the second half.

They play four roles. The **Juvenile Lead** is eager and slightly ridiculous — they have been told they have "stage presence" and have heard it as *promise*. The **Prompter** is them in a wooden box, frowning at the draught and the shorthand, pleased to be useful, faintly aware they are too young for the role and trying to compensate with seriousness. **An Actor** and the **Fifth Actor** are functions: someone has to read a line. They read them clean, no pretension, and look to Player 2 to check they did it right.

The casting note for the audition room: the actor — of any gender — must be young enough that the age difference reads from the back row, and a sharp enough listener that the company's whole second half can be tracked on their face. The audience must believe both that this is the youngest person in the room and that they are the one who understands soonest what the company has stumbled into. That is the role's range.

Act One, Part I — the Prompter takes the play down from the box while the Manager dictates the stage directions. The youngest in the company (a young man or woman), eager to be useful, faintly aware they are too young for the role.

PLAYER 3 *[reading the “book”]*. “Leo Gala’s house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study.”

THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man]*. Fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 *[noting it down]*. The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

THE MANAGER. Then make it red.

PLAYER 2. With what, sir? Hope? *[a beat]* Same flats as the blue room. I’ll turn them round.

PLAYER 3 *[reading from the “book”]*. “When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook’s cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup...”

THE MANAGER *[before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[it does not]* Mime them.

PLAYER 1 *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]*. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook’s cap?

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. It says so there. *[pointing to the “book”]*

PLAYER 1. But it’s *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook’s cap.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up from her clipboard]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

THE MANAGER *[rounding on him]*. Ridiculous? Of course it’s ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

PLAYER 1. The shell?

THE MANAGER. Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. *[more quietly]* And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

PLAYER 1 *[the threat empty; both of them know it]*. I’d sooner resign.

PLAYER 2. He resigns every Tuesday.

PLAYER 1 *[settling the cook’s cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold]*. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

THE MANAGER. The record is noted. The record is always noted. *[clapping]* Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There’s a draught off that door they’ve still not mended, and I’d rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

Madame Pace

the businesswoman of shame

Madame Pace is the seventh Character — and now her own performer. Pirandello marks her as the one figure not among the original Six, conjured onto the stage by its very arrangement: the hats on the pegs, the shop window the Property Man has set up (the sign reads *robes et manteaux*), the folding screen. In this edition she is no longer doubled by one of the Players; a single actor carries her and nothing else, so that when the door upstage opens and she walks through it, the audience meets a person who was not in the room a moment ago and cannot say how she got there. That is the Pirandellian trick, restored: not an actor stepping into a costume in view of the house, but an apparition who simply is there.

She is an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. She is a businesswoman of shame: elegant, practical, smiling, and morally rotten. She does not shout — her danger comes from being calm. Play the comedy of her accent at full strength on her arrival; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength by her exit. The audience laughs when she enters, and is disgusted with itself for having laughed by the time she leaves — that double sensation is the point of her. **Do not let her become an accent joke.** The accent is the entrance. The bookkeeping is the body of her.

The casting note for the audition room: this is the production's most theatrically demanding role, and it lives entirely in one scene. Cast for an actor with the physical control to land both ends of her — comic on arrival, chilling on exit — and the discipline to hold a smile that never drops while everything underneath it turns. The wig and the silver chain do half the work; the body and the voice do the rest. The accent must be performed with no protective irony. The audience must believe both that she is the funniest thing they have seen all night and that she is the most frightening. That is the role's range.

AUDITION SIDE — READ THIS

Act Two, Part II — Madame Pace materialises on the platform, conjured by the magic of the stage. She arrives comic, exits chilling. Her own performer carries the whole arc inside one scene.

MADAME PACE *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest, very pleased indeed to be here].* Good afternoon, good afternoon, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. *[A small bow to the room; the silver chain at her waist swings once.]* Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. *[Smiling, the smile of a hostess at her own front door.]* I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

Note. MADAME PACE speaks in a heavy accent, not in another language — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in French Lausanne too long and not long enough. The foreignness lives in the music of the voice and the broken grammar; the page keeps the words plain and lets the actor carry the sound. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.

THE MANAGER *[alarmed]*. What? What? She talks like that? *[The ACTORS burst out laughing again.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing]*. Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

MADAME PACE. It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. *[A small shrug, the smile.]* Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

THE MANAGER. Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

MADAME PACE. Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. *[The smile, unchanged.]* He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. *[The smile.]* And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

THE MOTHER *[jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her — and the voice that comes out of her is the one she has not used for years, and once it starts it comes out faster than her body can carry it]*. You old devil! You murderess! *[Trembling, but the voice does not stop.]* Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame, every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. *[Her hand, briefly, at her own chest.]* May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to calm her MOTHER — and a little frightened, perhaps, by the voice she has just heard come out of her]*. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

THE MOTHER *[she cannot quite stop yet; the voice has been waiting too long]*. And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

THE FATHER *[going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too].* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

THE MOTHER *[the voice short again now, as if she has spent what she had].* Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to MANAGER].* It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER].* They can't be here together — that's why that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the MOTHER and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

Meanwhile, the **STEP-DAUGHTER**, coming forward again, turns to **MADAME PACE**.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

MADAME PACE *[offended, but not loud — the offense of a businesswoman whose house rules have been questioned].* Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. *[Lifts a hand, as if to a small invisible bell.]* The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. *[Addressing the COMPANY imperiously.]* We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! *[To MADAME PACE.]* You can go!

MADAME PACE *[adjusting the silver chain at her waist; the scissors swing once].* Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. *[Pauses at the door. The smile returned, calm now, almost tender.]* And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. *[Beat. The voice softer, the smile unchanged.]* There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. *[The scissors swing once more at her waist.]* Don't you forget the name. *[Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]*